The Face of Crime in Prime Time: Evidence from Law and Order*

Gaurav Sood† Daniel Trielli‡

Abstract

Race, gender, and crime are inextricably linked in people's minds. These linkages exist in part because of what is shown on television. We investigate the extent to which popular television programming perpetuates these stereotypical linkages. We tally the race and gender of criminals and victims in three popular series of the most successful criminal procedural franchise on television—Law & Order. Data from episodes of *Special Victims Unit* and *Criminal Intent*, and seven seasons of the *Original* series reveal that whites are overrepresented (and blacks underrepresented) both as victims and criminals, while women are overrepresented as criminals. Underrepresentation of blacks is especially dramatic, with the percentages of blacks among violent-crime arrestees and serious-violent-crime victims nearly 400% and 200%, respectively, of the corresponding percentages on the shows.

Offensive portrayals of African Americans on entertainment shows have long been the norm in the US. For instance, minstrel shows, popular in the 19th century and the first half of the 20th century, regularly portrayed African Americans as lazy and dim-witted (Dates and Barlow 1993; Toll 1974). More recently, Entman and Rojecki (2001) found that 56% of blacks in the media were portrayed as violent compared to 11% of the whites.

There is good reason to think that these offensive portrayals reinforce negative stereotypes of African Americans. For at least some people likely take these portrayals as representative of African Americans (see Punyanunt-Carter 2008). Correspondingly, research suggests that belief in aversive racial stereotypes is associated with exposure to television programming (Busselle and Crandall 2002; Entman and Rojecki 2001; Armstrong and Neuendorf 1992). For instance, exposure to television news is correlated with the extent to which college students endorse that blacks are lazy (Busselle and Crandall 2002). Similarly, Armstrong and Neuendorf (1992) find that more television news the college students consumed, more likely they were to believe that blacks have lower socio-economic outcomes. (Albeit, "TV drama exposure was associated with beliefs that Black Americans had a relatively higher socio-economic standing.") A more comprehensive study of how blacks are portrayed in the media by Entman and Rojecki (2001) reached similar conclusions—exposure to nonfictional portrayals of African Americans is associated with negative stereotypes of blacks.

*Data and scripts behind the analysis presented here can be downloaded at: https://github.com/notnews/face_of_crime.

†Gaurav can be reached at gsood07@gmail.com

‡Daniel is a professional journalist. He can be reached at: dtrielli@gmail.com

Television's role in perpetuating negative stereotypes is worrisome because of how consequential stereotypes are in shaping attitudes, preferences, and behavior. Much research shows that racial stereotypes shape political attitudes (see, for e.g., Sniderman and Piazza 1995; Hurwitz and Peffley 1997; Peffley et al. 1997; Dixon 2006) and affect economic behavior (see, for e.g., Bertrand and Mullainathan 2004).

Given the concern, numerous researchers study how blacks are covered on various television programs (for e.g., Entman and Rojecki 2001; Eschholz et al. 2004). One particular focus of the effort—given blacks are stereotyped as violent and criminal, and given the impact such stereotypes may have on policy consequential attitudes related to punitiveness—has been on describing the extent to which blacks are overrepresented as criminals, especially as violent criminals.

Studies on the extent to which blacks are overrepresented in crime news or other programming about crime suggest that the bias is generally small but very variable—some studies document a modest anti-black bias in some news programs in some areas of the country (Gilliam et al. 1996), while others document a large anti-white bias (when compared to criminal arrest data, which are likely biased in favor of whites) (Chiricos and Eschholz 2002; Dixon and Linz 2000; Eschholz et al. 2004) (see Table 1).

Table 1: Racial Distribution of Perpetrators and Victims on Various Television Shows

Study and setting	Media	Key relevant findings
Agarwal et al. (2011) Hampton Roads, Virginia Jan. 3-31, 2011	Local TV News	Perpetrators: 50.7% Blacks (Violent Crime), 75% Whites (White Collar Crime), 75.9% Blacks (General Crime) (Graph 4) Victims: 78.3% White (Violent Crime), 82.1% Whites (General Crime) (Graph 5)
Dixon et al. (2003) National 1994–1997, 2000	Network News	Perpetrators: All Crime: 71% White (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 27% Blacks (vs. 30% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 4) Violent Crime: 48% White (vs. 56% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks (vs. 42% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 5) Victims: All Crime: 51% White (vs. 28% in Uniform Crime Reports), 30% Blacks (vs. 48% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 6)
Bjornstrom et al. (2010) National 2002–2003	Local TV News	Perpetrator (All Crime): 26.82% White, 21.06% Black, 42.27% Not Indicated Victim (All Crime): 27.88% White, 9.24% Black, 56.97% Not Indicated (Table 1)
Eschholz et al. (2004) National 2000–2001	NYPD Blue and Law and Order	NYPD Blue: Offender: 50% Whites (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks, 11% Violent Off./Sus. 43% (black) 46% (white) 10% Law and Order Figures don't add up to 100. (Table 1)

Table 1: Racial Distribution of Perpetrators and Victims on Various Television Shows (continued)

Study and setting	Media	Key relevant findings
Gross (2006) Washington, D.C. May and June 2005	Local TV News	Perpetrators: Violent Crime: 9% Whites, 32% Blacks, 51% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 14% Whites, 29% Blacks, 50% Unrevealed Victims: Violent Crime: 15% White, 10% Blacks, 72% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 3% White, 7% Blacks, 83% Unrevealed
Dixon and Linz (2000) Los Angeles 1995–1996	Local TV News	All Perpetrators: 37% Black (versus 21% in California Department of Justice Criminal Profile or CDJCP), 21% (versus 28% in CDJCP) (Table 4) Felons: 44% Black (versus 25% in CDJCP), 18% (versus 23% in CDJCP) (Table 5)
Gilliam et al. (1996) Los Angeles 1993–1994	Local TV News (KABC)	No commensurate numbers, except: 40% where race identified (purportedly across all crime stories). Where race identified in violent crime stories: 45% White and in non-violent crime: 75% white. Blacks actual crime rate: 2.8 * share of population. Coverage: 3.2 * share of population. (Assuming the coverage is estimated as percentage where race identified and not as percentage of total mentions) (Figure 2) Non-violent crime: Whites overrepresented by nearly 400% (see Figure 3)
Chiricos and Eschholz (2002) Orlando 1998	Local TV News	All Crime: 18% Black (Versus 42% Arrest Rate), 65% White (Versus 58% Arrest Rate) (Table 3) Violent Crime: 20% Black (Versus 49% Arrest Rate), 61% White (Versus 51% Arrest Rate)(Table 3)

In this paper, we add to this body of work. We tally the gender and race of criminals and victims depicted in three popular series of the criminal procedural, Law & Order. Compared to arrest records and victim survey data, all three series overrepresent whites as both criminals and victims and women as criminals.

Learning from Television

Mass media is an important part of the information environment for many people. Thus, what is covered in the media tends to affect what people believe (Gerbner et al. 1986; Shanahan and Morgan 1999). For instance, exposure to more vivid violent media causes people to think that crime and police immorality are more common in the real world (Riddle 2010). Similarly, the extent to which a topic is covered on television news affects how important people think it is (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Iyengar and Kinder 2010; Iyengar 1990).

Similar mechanism likely holds when someone watches one of the tens of hundreds of crime

dramas on television. A person watching a crime drama, aware of its fictional nature, may still inadvertently think that the drama accurately 'mirrors' society. For instance, people perceive negative personality traits of African Americans portrayed on television as true to life (Punyanunt-Carter 2008). These inference are liable to be encouraged by prior interpretation and acceptance of flawed—because they are imprecise—statements such as 'art reflects life' as true.

Increasingly common mass-media tropes such as realism in depiction and explicit statements designed to cue realism may also increase the chances that people take fictional portrayals as reasonably accurate depictions of reality. As a case in point, all Law & Order *Special Victims Unit* series episodes start with the statement: "...In New York City, the dedicated detectives who investigate these vicious felonies are members of an elite squad known as the Special Victims Unit. These are their stories." It is not unreasonable to think that some people listening to the statement may come to think that the crimes covered in the drama represent a broad, perhaps representative, set of all "sexually based crimes."

Besides learning about the extent of crime and what kind of crime is prevalent from television, people may also learn associations between kinds of people and criminal activity, especially when people involved are (superficially) distinctive—say, in the color of their skin. The logic goes that if certain kinds of people are frequently shown as perpetrators of crime, people may come to believe that as large a share of perpetrators belongs to that group. By the same token, over-representation of certain groups as victims may promote misleading views of what populations are the most vulnerable to crime.

Data and Measurement

The data are from three Law & Order series: Original Law & Order series (Original), Law & Order: Special Victims Unit (SVU), and Law & Order: Criminal Intent (Criminal Intent). All the three shows are police procedurals set in New York City. Criminal Intent, which ran between 2001–2011, purportedly follows detectives of the 'Major Case Squad,' a division of the New York Police Department (NYPD) focused on solving major crimes against rich, famous, or important people. Meanwhile SVU, which has been on television since 1999, purportedly follows detectives of the NYPD division devoted to handling "sexually based offenses," the 'Special Victims Unit.'

All three shows have enjoyed great success. At the time of data collection, the Original Law & Order was the longest running scripted US prime time TV series on a major broadcast network, and SVU was the longest running scripted non-animated US prime time TV series then on air. Through its run, Criminal Intent drew an average of 9.3M people, Original, an average of 10.2M, and SVU, an average of 11.81M.[1]

For the Original series, we only have data from Seasons 1 and 2 (1990–1992) and Seasons 16–20

[1]Based on data assembled by Austin Ogilvie at https://github.com/hernamesbarbara/law_and_order from Wikipedia and TV.com.

(2005–2010).[2] In all, we have data from 151 shows. For CI, we have data on 194 shows aired across its 10 seasons, spanning 2001–2011. And for SVU, we have data on 386 shows from seasons 1–17, broadcast between 1999 and 2016. In all, across the three series, we have data from 731 shows, featuring 1,578 victims of crime, and 1,117 criminals. We coded the race and gender of all criminals and victims whose race and gender was identified.

We define criminals as characters whose guilt is very clearly indicated; our definition includes characters not convicted or even indicted for a crime. In line with the law, active instigators and financiers of crime were coded as criminals. We marked attempted crimes as such. Lastly, we focus on 'major' crimes, excluding infractions such as failing to comply with court orders.

We coded victims' and criminals' race as white, black, Asian, or Hispanic, following the general census guidelines.[3] Characters of Middle-Eastern descent were coded as white, but a note marking their specific background was included in the data. And under 'Hispanics,' we included non-Hispanic Latinos such as Brazilians.

In addition to the data on the race and gender of the victims and the criminals from the shows, we collected data on a few baselines. From the 1990, 2000, and 2010 census, we collected data on the percentage of whites, blacks, and men in the US and in New York City. Like Dixon and Linz (2000), from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Report (UCR), we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and men arrested for *All Crimes*, *Violent Crimes*, and *Sexually Based Crimes*. From New York Police Department's Crime and Enforcement Activity in New York City Report (NYPD),[4] we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and Hispanics who were suspected of (and were victims of) murder, rape, assault and robbery each year between 2008 and 2015. Lastly, from the Bureau of Justice Statistics' National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS) (Powers 2016; Victimization 1998), we gathered data on the race and gender of victims of crime.

The UCR data on race of alleged criminals is available for 1995–2015. In UCR, race is split into white, black, American Indian or Alaskan Native, Asian, and Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander. The totals in these categories include Hispanics. Data on Hispanic background only began to be collected in 2013, and even then the race totals are not split by Hispanic ethnicity. Not separating out Hispanics naturally inflates the numbers for whites and blacks. But the inflation for blacks is quite modest. Nearly 93% of Hispanics self-identify as whites (Steffensmeier et al. 2011). And accounting for Hispanics changes the percentage of blacks rape and assault by generally no more than a couple of percentage points (see figure 4, Steffensmeier et al. 2011).[5] Thus, for the main analyses, which focus on representation of blacks and Hispanics, we utilize unadjusted numbers for blacks from UCR.

In UCR, 28 types of crimes are split into two categories: *Violent Crime* and *Property Crime*.

[2] The choice of the seasons is a reflection of what was available on streaming on Amazon Instant as of July, 2016.

[3] http://www.census.gov/topics/population/race/about.html

[4] http://www.nyc.gov/html/nypd/html/analysis_and_planning/crime_and_enforcement_activity.shtml

[5] Steffensmeier et al. (2011) adjust UCR data by leveraging arrest data from California and New York, where arrest data includes Hispanics.

Violent Crime includes murder and non-negligent manslaughter, rape, robbery, and aggravated assault. And *Property Crime* includes burglary, larceny-theft, motor vehicle theft, and arson. We collected data on the percentage of people arrested by race (white and black) and gender (male) for all crimes, violent crimes, as well as arrested for three of the most common offenses shown in the Law & Order shows: homicides, rapes, and assaults. (659 of 731 shows or just over 90% of the shows included in our data featured a rape, murder, or assault.)

Victim data from the NCVS covers the period between 1993–2014. Racial data in the NCVS can be gathered with Hispanics included in the category totals, and without. We collected both kinds of data, but focus on data that more closely matches our data for Law & Order, and separates out Hispanics.

Like the UCR, the NCVS aggregates various crimes into categories. In NCVS, however, the categories are *Violent Victimization* and *Serious Violent Victimization*. Both account for victims of rape, sexual assault, and robbery. *Violent Victimization*, however, tallies all types of assault, while *Serious Violent Victimization* only tallies aggravated assaults. Therefore, *Serious Violent Victimization* is the closest to the *Violent Crime* category in the UCR. Hence, we use data from that category. In addition, we also collect data for two specific offenses: rape/sexual assault and aggravated assault. Given that the NCVS data comes from interviews with victims, there is naturally no data on murders. Data on the race and gender of murder victims comes from UCR.[6]

Results

To study how racial and gender breakdown of criminals and victims in Law & Order compares to 'the real world,' we compare the percentage of black and female criminals and victims on the three Law & Order shows to a variety of baselines. In the main text, we describe these percentages by show across all coded episodes. Our data label crimes by episode; they do not link each victim or criminal to a particular crime. We compare the show percentages to percentages of black, Hispanic, and female arrestees for all crimes, rape, and murder from the UCR, and percentages of black and female victims for murder, rape, and serious violent crimes. Each reference percentage pools records from the available years in which at least one coded episode from any of the three shows aired. A series of graphs and tables in SI 1 and SI 2 break data down by year, and provide other baselines like data from the census that we don't include in the main text.

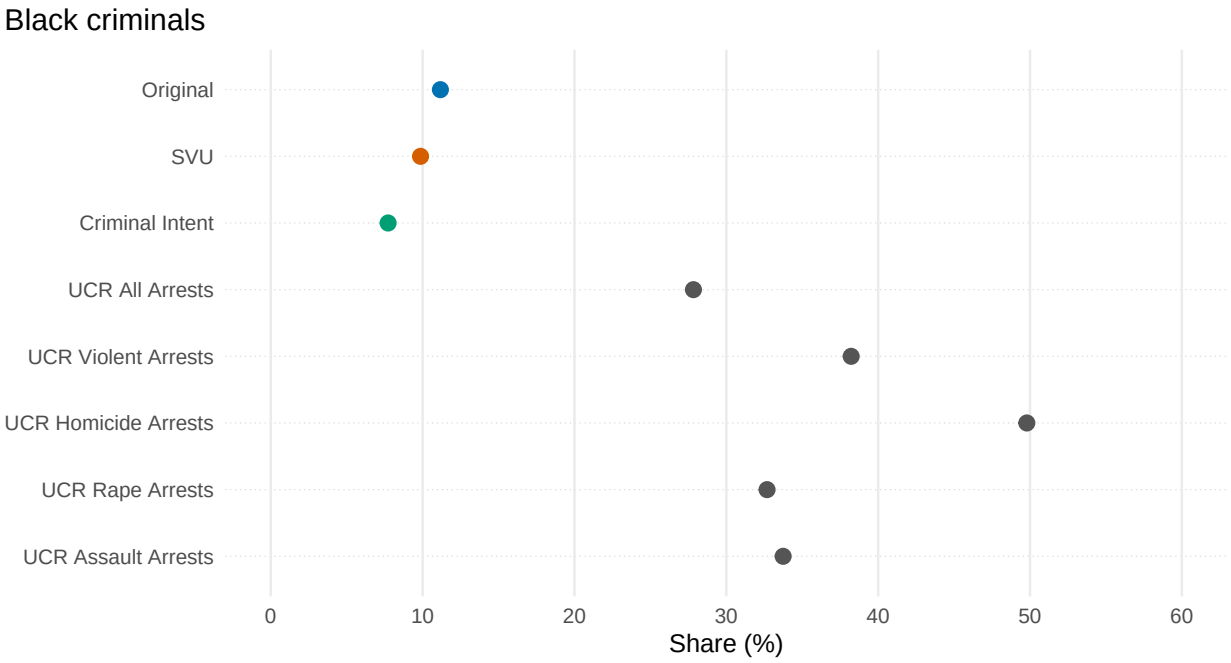
As Figure 1 and Figure 2 show, criminals on all three shows were overwhelmingly white. About

[6]Since homicides almost always lead to the discovery of the bodies of victims, data on their gender and race are usually present. In 2015, for instance, there were 13,455 homicide victims. Of those, 29 (0.2 percent) were of an unknown gender. Thus, for data about gender of homicide victims, the percentages we use are the same offered by the UCR, which are calculated on the total of homicide victims, even the ones whose gender is unknown as that has a negligible impact on the final numbers. For instance, if we include victims with unknown gender—which is done by UCR—78.8 percent of all victims were male. Excluding those, the percentage changes to 79.0 percent. For perpetrators, we also use percentages offered by the UCR, but there is a high number of perpetrators unknown gender. Therefore, the percentages are based on the total of perpetrators whose gender is known.

82%–86% of the criminals in each of the shows were white. The figures also illustrate that blacks are dramatically underrepresented among the coded criminals relative to the arrest records. Hispanic arrest counts begin in 2013 and overlap only with coded SVU episodes. The percentage of black criminals in the three series is between one-fifth and one-third of the percentage of Blacks arrested for violent crimes (see Figure 1).

Looking at percentage of black criminals by year—all episodes broadcast in a year; generally includes episodes from two seasons—we see no discernible pattern (see Figure SI 1.1 and Table SI 2.2). However, one fact deserves closer attention. The FBI approved a change in its definition of rape in 2011, from 'carnal knowledge of a female forcibly and against her will' to 'Penetration, no matter how slight, of the vagina or anus with any body part or object, or oral penetration by a sex organ of another person, without the consent of the victim.' The UCR began using the new definition in 2013. The new definition for the first time accounted for male rape. As we can see in Table SI 2.2, the proportion of rape arrestees who are black changed by about one percentage point between 2012 and 2013.

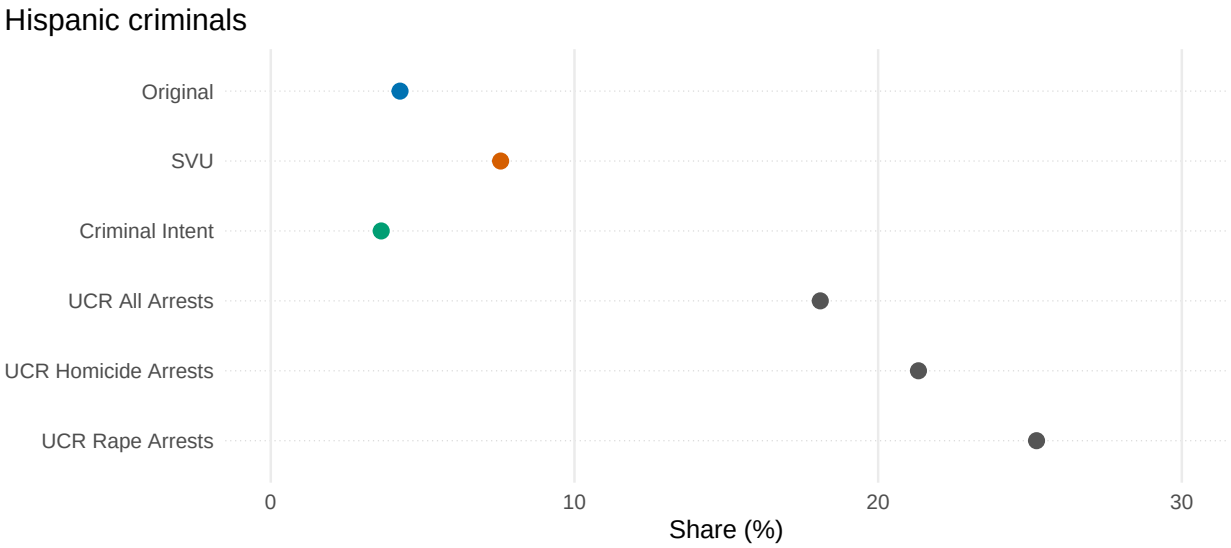
Figure 1: Share of Black Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World



Colored dots pool classified criminal characters. UCR dots pool arrests.
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.
UCR Black includes Hispanics.

Not only were the perpetrators of crime overwhelmingly white, so were the victims (see Figure 3). About 73%–82% of the victims depicted in all three shows were white, and only about 10 percent were black. In the NCVS, the percentage of serious violent victimizations involving black victims

Figure 2: Share of Hispanic Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World



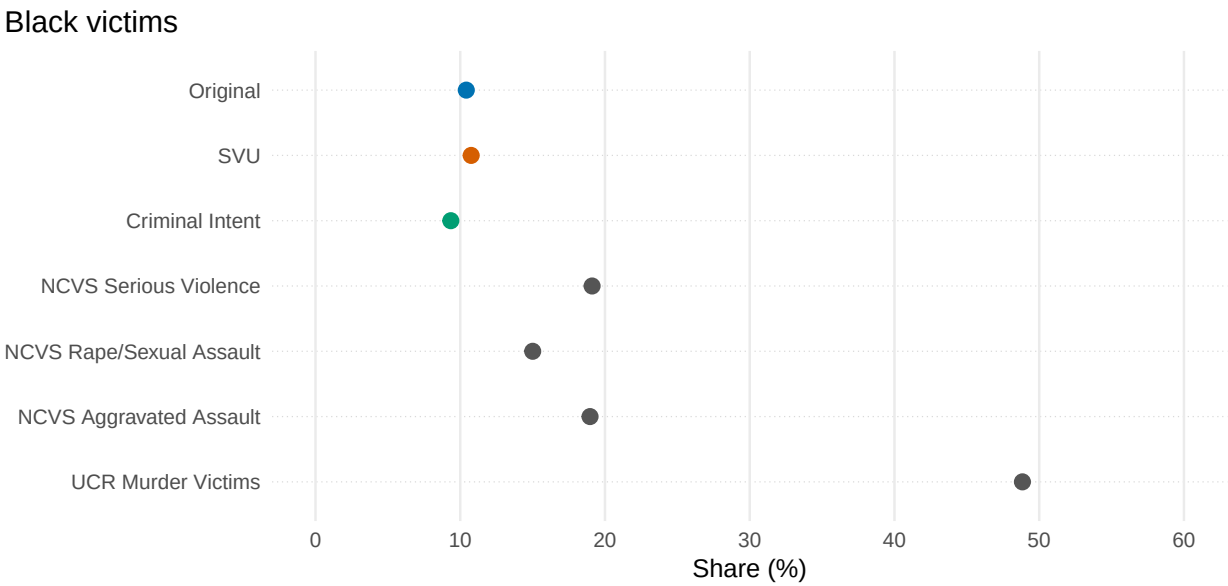
Colored dots pool classified criminal characters. UCR dots pool arrests.
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.
UCR ethnicity counts begin in 2013 and cover arrests with reported ethnicity.

between 1999 and 2014 was 19.1%. The corresponding number for rape or sexual assault was 15.0%, for aggravated assault, 19.0%, and the UCR percentage of murder victims who were black between 1999 and 2015 was 48.8% (see Figure 3). Splitting the data by year and tallying the percentage of victims who were black revealed no discernible time trend across shows (see Figure SI 1.2 and Table SI 2.1).

Moving to gender, nearly 30% of the criminals were women across the three shows (see Figure 5). Once again, there was no distinct over time pattern in percentage of criminals who were men across the three shows (see Figure SI 1.3 and Table SI 2.4). The percentage of female criminals in the UCR arrest data is lower—about 11% of homicide arrestees, 1%–3% of rape arrestees, and 17%–20% of those arrested for a violent crime. The NCVS also records victims' reports of offender sex; Figure 5 shows the percentage of serious-violent victimizations involving female-only offenders among incidents with known offender sex. But once again, we note the change in definition of rape in the UCR in 2013. The proportion of women among rape arrestees rises by about one percentage point from 2012 to 2013 (Table SI 2.4).

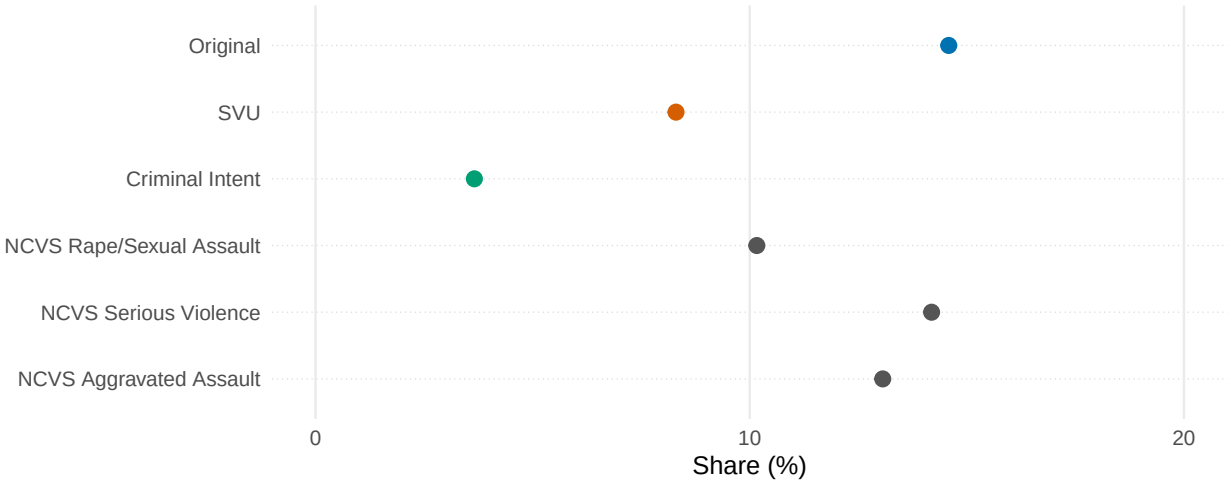
When we looked at the gender of victims, there was an expected sizable variation across shows, with female victims constituting roughly 40% of all the victims on Criminal Intent and Original and just over 60% on SVU (see Figure 6). Except for CI, where there appears to be a downward trend post 2005, there were no discernible time trends (see Figure SI 1.4 and Table SI 2.3). In the NCVS, the percentage of serious violent victimizations involving women is about 47.1%, while the percentage for rape or sexual assault is a distressing 88.7%. In the UCR, 22.3% of murder victims

Figure 3: Share of Black Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



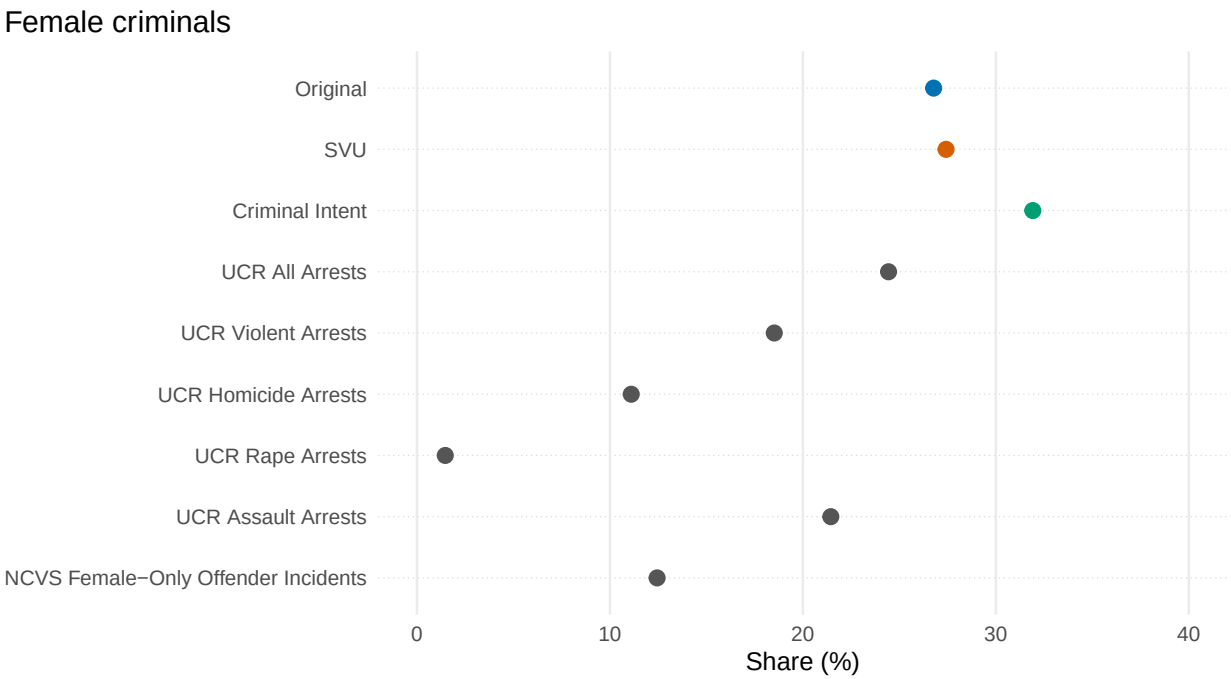
Colored dots pool classified victim characters.
NCVS dots pool weighted victimizations (survey estimates; SEs not shown); UCR dots pool murder victims.
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.
NCVS Black excludes Hispanics; UCR Black includes Hispanics.

Figure 4: Share of Hispanic Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



Colored dots pool classified victim characters.
NCVS dots pool weighted victimizations (survey estimates; SEs not shown).
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.

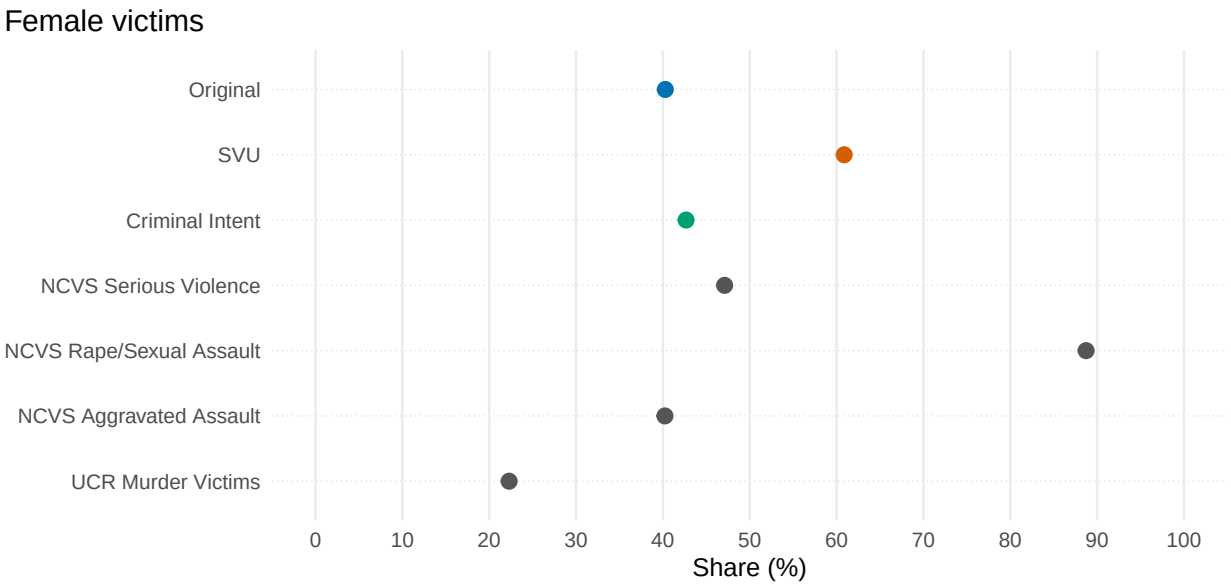
Figure 5: Share of Female Criminals in Law & Order and the Real World



Colored dots pool classified criminal characters. UCR dots pool arrests.
NCVS: serious−violence incidents with victim−reported female−only offenders
among known−sex incidents (SEs not shown);
mixed−sex groups remain in the denominator.
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.

are women.

Figure 6: Share of Female Victims in Law & Order and the Real World



Colored dots pool classified victim characters.
NCVS dots pool weighted victimizations (survey estimates; SEs not shown); UCR dots pool murder victims.
Each gray reference dot pools available years in which any coded episode aired.

Discussion

Popular television is our bay window to the world. What we see on television likely has a sizable influence on how we think about the world. In particular, television programming likely influences how we think about crime, how common we think it is, especially in our communities, who we think perpetrates it, the reasons why criminals do what they do, who the victims are, the efficacy of the police and judicial systems, among other things.

In this essay, we shed light on whether a popular police procedural perpetuates adversarial stereotypes about blacks, and in doing so shed light on racial and gender imbalance in portrayal of criminals and victims. In line with other evidence (see Table 1), we find that contrary to worries about overrepresentation of blacks as criminals, whites are overrepresented as perpetrators and, to a smaller degree, as victims, compared with the records we collected. We also find that women are overrepresented as criminals. These imbalances likely affect people's perceptions of who the criminals and victims are. For instance, naive but avid viewers of Law & Order may come to believe that the share of perpetrators and victims of crime who are white is substantially higher than it is. This, in turn, may shape their views about crime and policies that are likely to be most efficacious in reducing crime. For instance, they may become persuaded that greater policing of

white neighborhoods is needed. Similar such shaping of policy consequential attitudes is easy to fathom.

Beyond its potential impact on policy attitude consequential beliefs, the racial and gender asymmetries also hint at the beliefs and motives of the writers and producers of the show. One potential reason for asymmetries may be that writers and producers are politically liberal. In particular, the writers and producers may have reasoned that the audience is liable to swap $p(\text{black}|\text{criminal})$ with $p(\text{criminal}|\text{black})$ (see, for instance, Bordalo et al. Forthcoming; Ahler and Sood 2016) and altered race to address such concerns. Or the profit motive may have weighed in on their decisions. By exaggerating the share of white victims and criminals, they may have thought that they would be able to instill greater fear (and thrill) in the white audience members. Or it may be something else entirely. Whatever the genesis of the decisions about race and gender of criminals and victims, our purpose in this essay was to merely describe the decisions. And that the racial and gender breakdown of victims and criminals on the show goes against conventional wisdom is likely worthy of notice.

References

Vinod Agarwal, Susan Hughes, Janet Molinaro, Ayush Toolsidass, Chris Colburn, Elizabeth Janik, Ken Plum, Shara Weber, Vicky Curtis, Feng Lian, Jim Sylvester, Gilbert Yochum, Steve Daniel, and Sharon Lomax. If it bleeds, does it still lead? local television evening news in hampton roads. In *The State of the Region*, pages 131–150. Old Dominion University, 2011.

Douglas J Ahler and Gaurav Sood. The parties in our heads: Misperceptions about party composition and their consequences. 2016.

G Blake Armstrong and Kimberly A Neuendorf. Tv entertainment, news, and racial perceptions of college students. *Journal of Communication*, 42(3):153–176, 1992.

Marianne Bertrand and Sendhil Mullainathan. Are emily and greg more employable than lakisha and jamal? a field experiment on labor market discrimination. *The American Economic Review*, 94(4):991–1013, 2004.

Eileen ES Bjornstrom, Robert L Kaufman, Ruth D Peterson, and Michael D Slater. Race and ethnic representations of lawbreakers and victims in crime news: A national study of television coverage. *Social problems*, 57(2):269–293, 2010.

Pedro Bordalo, Katherine Coffman, Nicola Gennaioli, and Andrei Shleifer. Stereotypes. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, Forthcoming.

Rick Busselle and Heather Crandall. Television viewing and perceptions about race differences in socioeconomic success. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 46(2):265–282, 2002.

Ted Chiricos and Sarah Eschholz. The racial and ethnic typification of crime and the criminal typification of race and ethnicity in local television news. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency*, 39(4):400–420, 2002.

Jannette Lake Dates and William Barlow. *Split image: African Americans in the mass media*. Howard University Press, 1993.

Travis L Dixon. Psychological reactions to crime news portrayals of black criminals: Understanding the moderating roles of prior news viewing and stereotype endorsement. *Communication Monographs*, 73(2):162–187, 2006.

Travis L Dixon, Cristina L Azocar, and Michael Casas. The portrayal of race and crime on television network news. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 47(4):498–523, 2003.

Travis Lemar Dixon and Daniel Linz. Overrepresentation and underrepresentation of african americans and latinos as lawbreakers on television news. *Journal of communication*, 50(2):131–154, 2000.

Robert M Entman and Andrew Rojecki. *The black image in the white mind: Media and race in America*. Wiley Online Library, 2001.

Sarah Eschholz, Matthew Mallard, and Stacey Flynn. Images of prime time justice: a content analysis of "nypd blue" and "law & order". *Journal of Criminal Justice and Popular Culture*, 10 (3):161–180, 2004.

George Gerbner, Larry Gross, Michael Morgan, and Nancy Signorielli. Living with television: The dynamics of the cultivation process. *Perspectives on media effects*, pages 17–40, 1986.

Franklin D Gilliam, Shanto Iyengar, Adam Simon, and Oliver Wright. Crime in black and white the violent, scary world of local news. *The Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics*, 1 (3):6–23, 1996.

Kimberly Gross. Covering crime in washington, dc: Examining the nature of local television news coverage of crime and its effect on emotional response. 2006.

Jon Hurwitz and Mark Peffley. Public perceptions of race and crime: The role of racial stereotypes. *American journal of political science*, pages 375–401, 1997.

Shanto Iyengar. The accessibility bias in politics: Television news and public opinion. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 2(1):1–15, 1990.

Shanto Iyengar and Donald R Kinder. *News that matters: Television and American opinion*. University of Chicago Press, 2010.

Maxwell E McCombs and Donald L Shaw. The agenda-setting function of mass media. *Public opinion quarterly*, 36(2):176–187, 1972.

Mark Peffley, Jon Hurwitz, and Paul M Sniderman. Racial stereotypes and whites' political views of blacks in the context of welfare and crime. *American Journal of Political Science*, pages 30–60, 1997.

Ráchael A Powers. National crime victimization survey. *The Encyclopedia of Crime & Punishment*, 2016.

Narissra M Punyanunt-Carter. The perceived realism of african american portrayals on television. *The Howard Journal of Communications*, 19(3):241–257, 2008.

Karyn Riddle. Always on my mind: Exploring how frequent, recent, and vivid television portrayals are used in the formation of social reality judgments. *Media Psychology*, 13(2):155–179, 2010.

James Shanahan and Michael Morgan. *Television and its viewers: Cultivation theory and research*. Cambridge University Press, 1999.

Paul M Sniderman and Thomas Leonard Piazza. *The scar of race*. Harvard University Press, 1995.

Darrell Steffensmeier, Ben Feldmeyer, Casey T Harris, and Jeffery T Ulmer. Reassessing trends in black violent crime, 1980–2008: Sorting out the "hispanic effect" in uniform crime reports arrests, national crime victimization survey offender estimates, and us prisoner counts. *Criminology*, 49 (1):197–251, 2011.

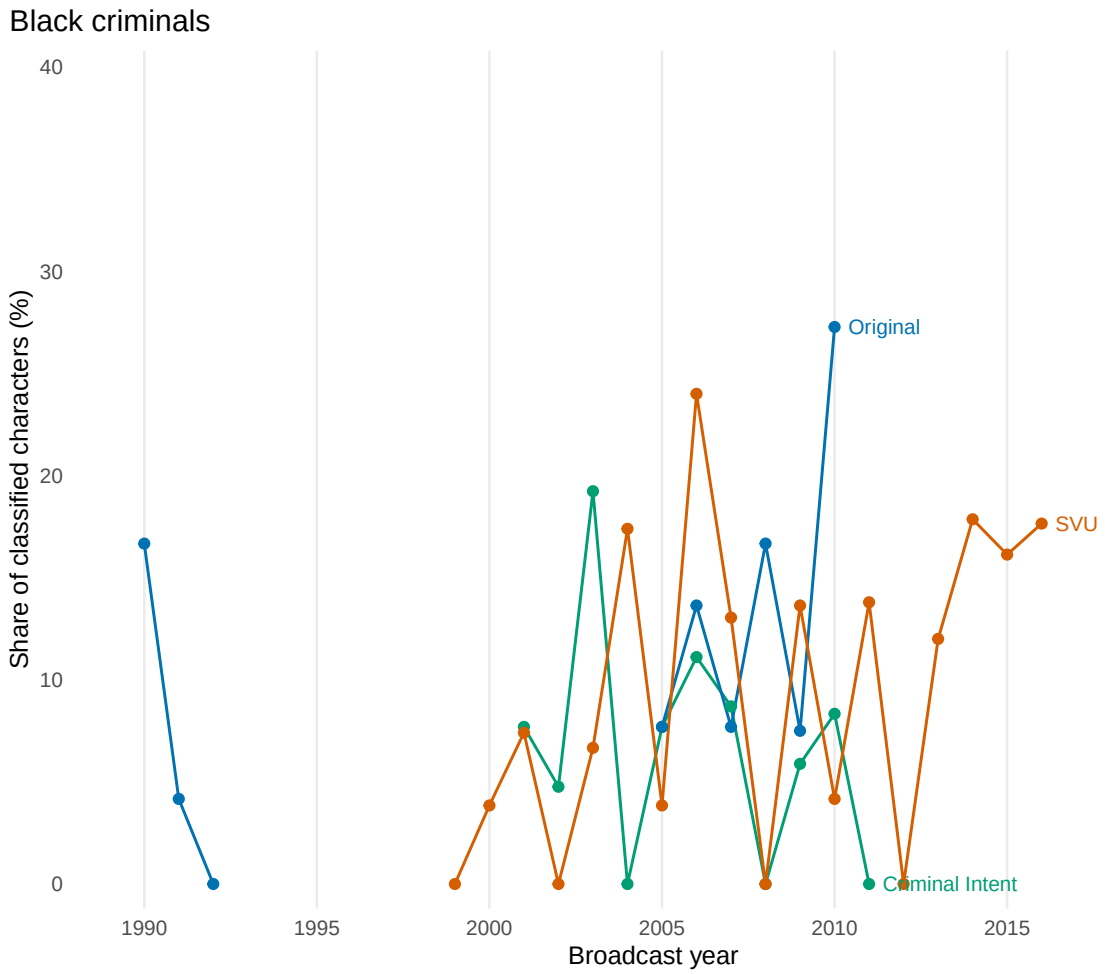
Robert C Toll. *Blacking up: The minstrel show in nineteenth century America*. Oxford University Press, 1974.

Criminal Victimization. National crime victimization survey. *Washington, DC: US Dept of justice*, 1998.

Supporting Information

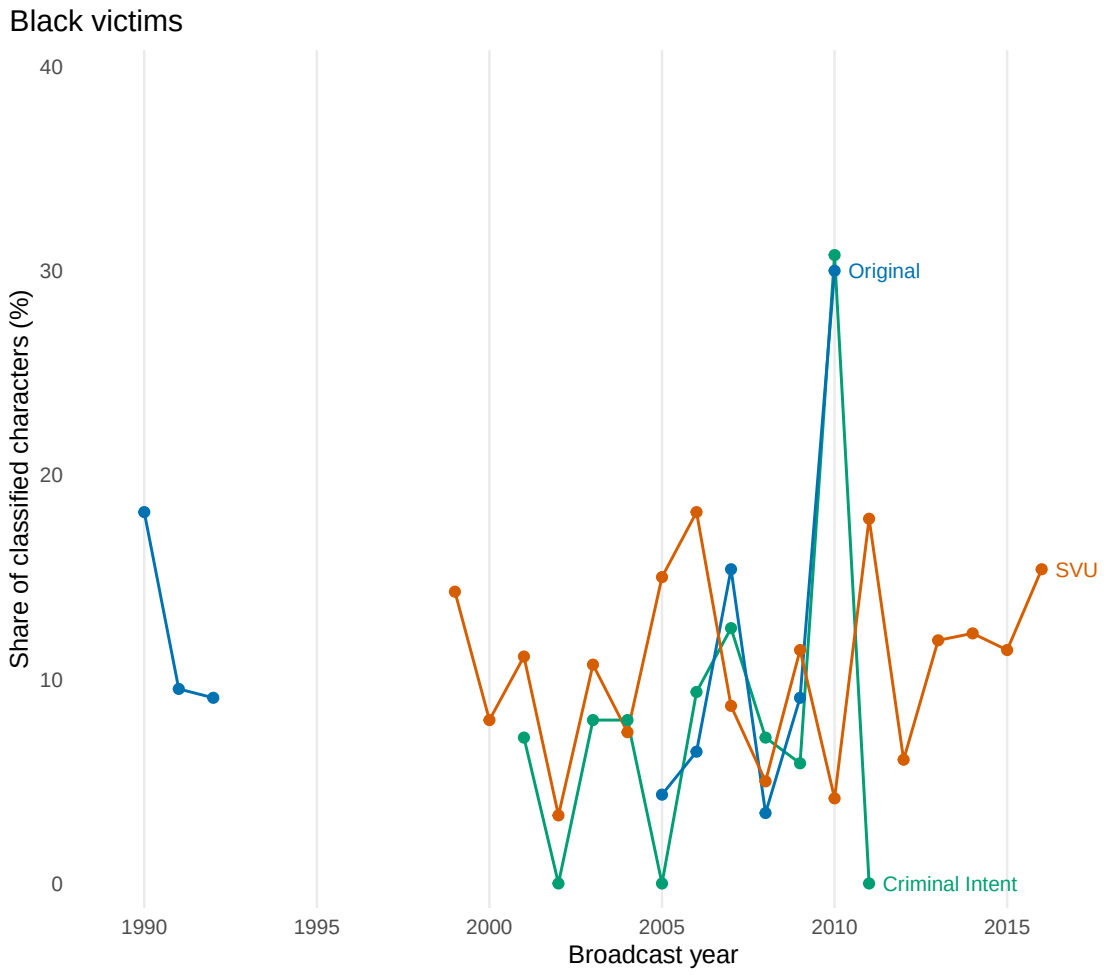
SI 1 Percentage of Black and Female Criminals and Victims in Law & Order By Year

Figure SI 1.1: Race of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



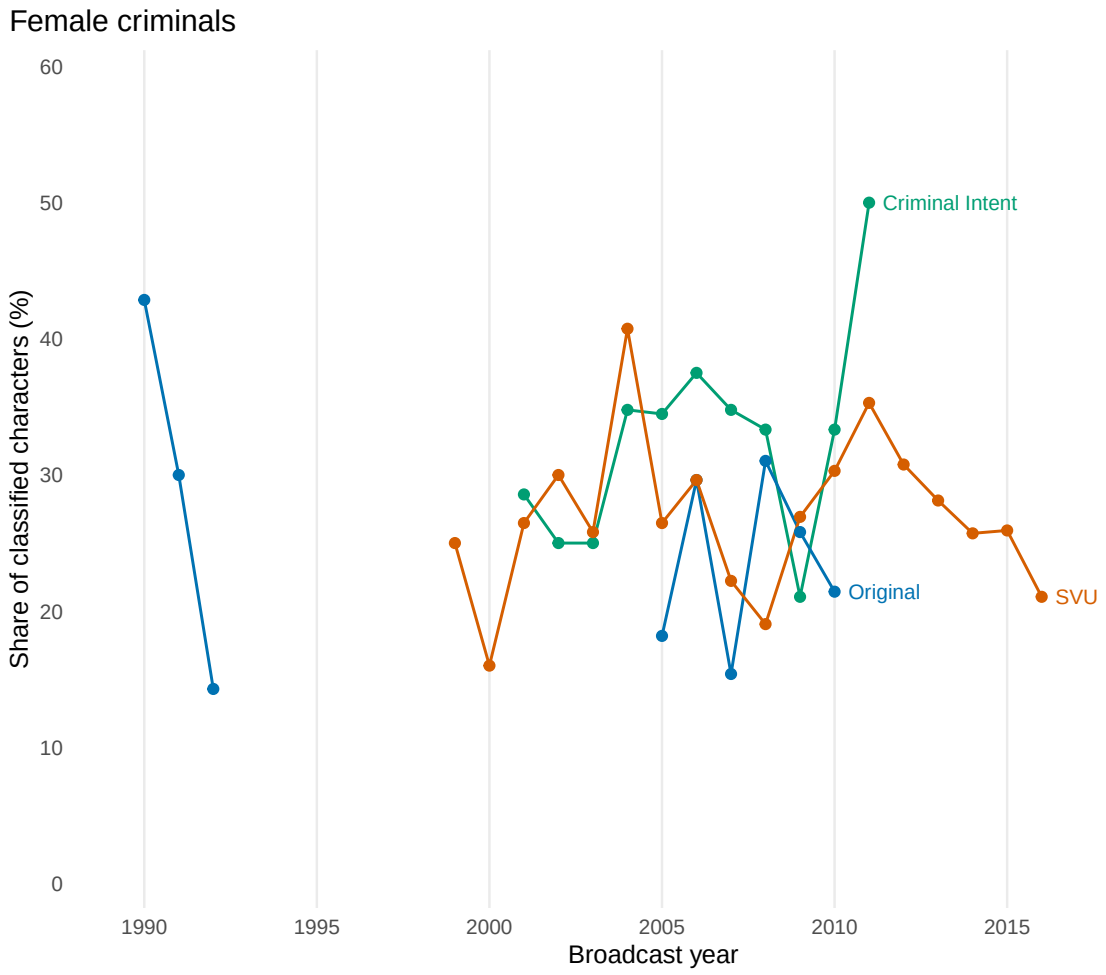
Each annual value pools characters across coded episodes broadcast that year.

Figure SI 1.2: Race of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



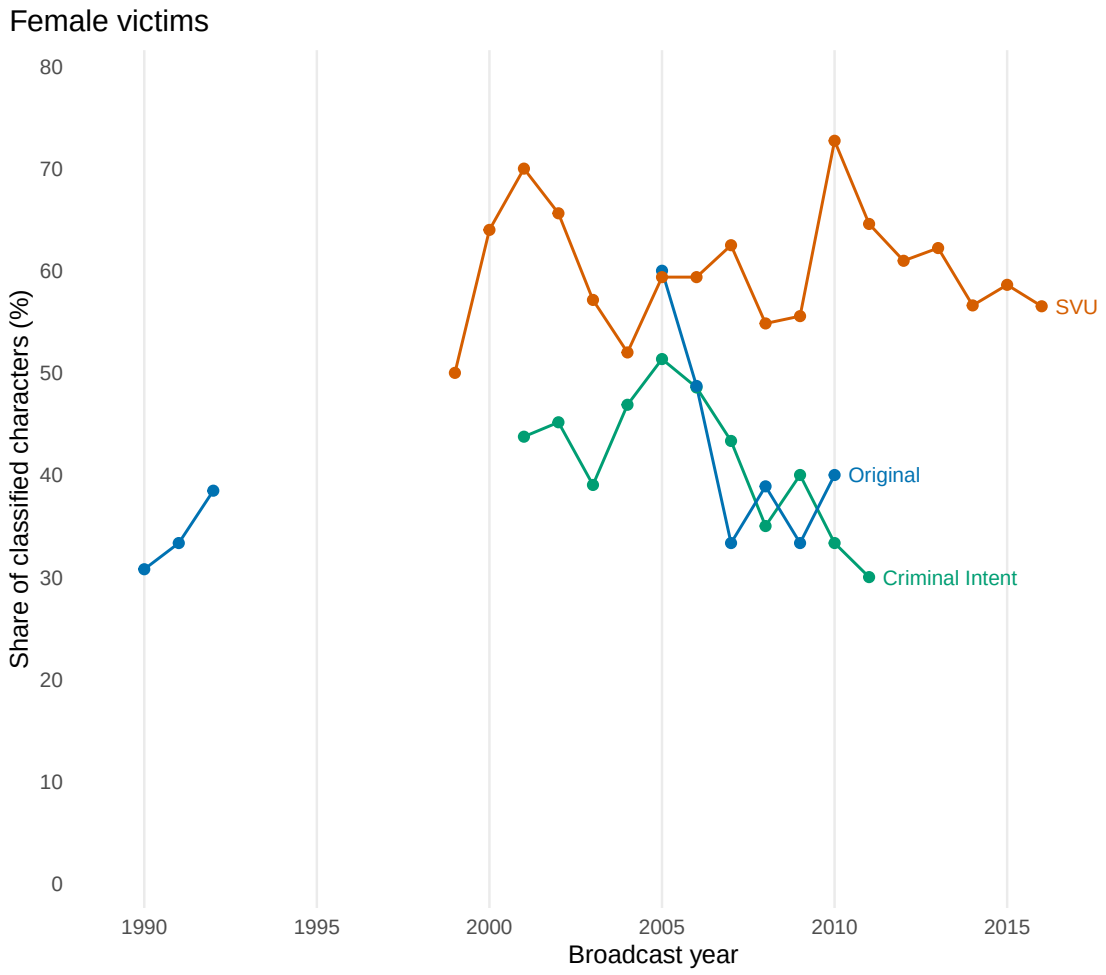
Each annual value pools characters across coded episodes broadcast that year.

Figure SI 1.3: Gender of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



Each annual value pools characters across coded episodes broadcast that year.

Figure SI 1.4: Gender of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



Each annual value pools characters across coded episodes broadcast that year.

SI 2 Sex and Race of Criminals and Victims in Law & Order and the Real World

Table SI 2.1: Annual share of black victim characters and historical comparisons

	Coded episodes			NCVS			UCR	NYPD		Census	
Year	CI	Original	SVU	Serious	Rape/SA	Aggravated	Murder	Homicide	Rape	US	NY
1990	–	18.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	9.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	9.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	14.3	21.0	15.0	18.9	46.3	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	8.0	15.8	9.2	13.4	47.8	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.1	–	11.1	18.2	22.1	18.5	46.9	–	–	–	–
2002	0.0	–	3.3	21.9	27.3	21.8	47.9	–	–	–	–
2003	8.0	–	10.7	14.5	7.4	12.6	47.8	–	–	–	–
2004	8.0	–	7.4	19.7	19.1	16.5	47.0	–	–	–	–
2005	0.0	4.3	15.0	19.0	24.9	20.3	47.9	–	–	–	–
2006	9.4	6.5	18.2	20.9	18.9	26.5	49.5	–	–	–	–
2007	12.5	15.4	8.7	24.5	6.3	24.0	49.3	–	–	–	–
2008	7.1	3.4	5.0	17.9	16.3	16.1	47.8	62.1	40.6	–	–
2009	5.9	9.1	11.4	25.3	12.7	23.7	48.1	57.6	40.5	–	–
2010	30.8	30.0	4.2	18.6	12.2	20.0	49.8	67.0	40.9	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	17.9	17.9	14.7	17.9	50.0	61.8	36.8	–	–
2012	–	–	6.1	17.4	5.6	18.1	50.6	60.1	37.9	–	–
2013	–	–	11.9	15.8	7.7	19.7	51.1	62.9	40.8	–	–
2014	–	–	12.2	16.3	17.6	14.5	51.0	62.4	39.7	–	–
2015	–	–	11.4	–	–	–	52.3	63.7	39.4	–	–
2016	–	–	15.4	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Coded columns: Black share of classified victim characters in episodes broadcast that year. NCVS: weighted victimizations (serious = rape/sexual assault, robbery, and aggravated assault); UCR: murder victims; NYPD: victims. Census: population. NCVS Black excludes Hispanics; UCR and NYPD Black categories include Hispanics. Entries are percentages; – denotes no data.

Table SI 2.2: Annual share of black criminal characters and historical comparisons

	Coded episodes			UCR					NYPD		Census	
Year	CI	Original	SVU	All	Violent	Homicide	Rape	Assault	Homicide	Rape	US	NY
1990	–	16.7	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	4.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	0.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	0.0	28.6	38.7	51.8	36.2	34.8	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	3.8	27.9	37.8	48.8	34.1	34.0	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.7	–	7.4	28.1	37.6	48.7	34.8	33.7	–	–	–	–
2002	4.8	–	0.0	26.9	38.0	50.0	34.0	34.2	–	–	–	–
2003	19.2	–	6.7	27.0	37.2	48.5	33.3	33.0	–	–	–	–
2004	0.0	–	17.4	26.8	36.9	47.2	31.9	32.7	–	–	–	–
2005	7.7	7.7	3.8	27.8	38.8	48.6	32.7	34.3	–	–	–	–
2006	11.1	13.6	24.0	28.0	39.3	50.9	32.5	34.5	–	–	–	–
2007	8.7	7.7	13.0	28.2	39.0	50.4	33.5	33.7	–	–	–	–
2008	0.0	16.7	0.0	28.3	39.4	50.1	32.2	34.2	60.8	52.8	–	–
2009	5.9	7.5	13.6	28.3	38.9	49.3	32.5	33.9	59.8	52.4	–	–
2010	8.3	27.3	4.2	28.0	38.1	48.7	31.8	33.5	60.9	52.6	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	13.8	28.4	38.3	49.7	32.9	33.6	56.3	48.8	–	–
2012	–	–	0.0	28.1	38.5	49.4	32.5	34.1	53.7	50.5	–	–
2013	–	–	12.0	28.3	38.7	52.2	31.3	33.9	55.0	53.0	–	–
2014	–	–	17.9	27.8	37.7	51.3	29.9	33.1	59.8	49.3	–	–
2015	–	–	16.1	26.6	36.4	51.1	28.2	32.1	62.1	51.2	–	–
2016	–	–	17.6	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Coded columns: Black share of classified criminal characters in episodes broadcast that year. UCR: arrests; NYPD: suspects. Census: population. UCR and NYPD Black categories include Hispanics. Entries are percentages; – denotes no data.

Table SI 2.3: Annual share of female victim characters and historical comparisons

	Coded episodes			NCVS			UCR	Census	
Year	CI	Original	SVU	Serious	Rape/SA	Aggravated	Murder	US	NY
1990	–	30.8	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	33.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	38.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	50.0	48.2	93.3	39.2	24.4	–	–
2000	–	–	64.0	38.1	96.0	27.1	23.8	50.9	52.6
2001	43.8	–	70.0	49.0	90.1	41.1	23.4	–	–
2002	45.2	–	65.6	49.3	86.6	44.0	23.1	–	–
2003	39.0	–	57.1	50.7	94.0	41.6	22.3	–	–
2004	46.9	–	52.0	45.4	97.6	37.1	21.9	–	–
2005	51.4	60.0	59.4	40.1	92.7	39.3	21.2	–	–
2006	48.6	48.7	59.4	47.4	77.6	42.5	21.1	–	–
2007	43.3	33.3	62.5	46.5	95.5	39.0	21.4	–	–
2008	35.0	38.9	54.8	54.9	88.7	47.2	21.7	–	–
2009	40.0	33.3	55.6	49.4	93.5	45.0	22.9	–	–
2010	33.3	40.0	72.7	52.5	94.4	43.2	22.5	50.8	52.5
2011	30.0	–	64.6	47.5	85.7	43.0	22.2	–	–
2012	–	–	61.0	42.3	62.2	42.5	22.2	–	–
2013	–	–	62.2	49.0	88.7	39.1	22.1	–	–
2014	–	–	56.6	46.9	90.1	39.6	22.4	–	–
2015	–	–	58.6	–	–	–	20.9	–	–
2016	–	–	56.5	–	–	–	–	–	–

Coded columns: female share of classified victim characters in episodes broadcast that year. NCVS: weighted victimizations (serious = rape/sexual assault, robbery, and aggravated assault); UCR: murder victims. Census: population. Entries are percentages; – denotes no data.

Table SI 2.4: Annual share of female criminal characters and historical comparisons

	Coded episodes			NCVS	UCR					Census	
Year	CI	Original	SVU	Female-only	All	Violent	Homicide	Rape	Assault	US	NY
1990	–	42.9	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	30.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	14.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	25.0	11.3	21.8	17.0	11.4	1.3	19.7	–	–
2000	–	–	16.0	8.6	22.2	17.4	10.6	1.1	20.1	50.9	52.6
2001	28.6	–	26.5	10.0	22.5	17.3	12.5	1.2	20.1	–	–
2002	25.0	–	30.0	10.4	23.0	17.4	10.8	1.4	20.2	–	–
2003	25.0	–	25.8	9.2	23.2	17.8	10.3	1.3	20.7	–	–
2004	34.8	–	40.7	13.5	23.8	17.9	11.5	1.5	20.8	–	–
2005	34.5	18.2	26.5	15.7	23.8	17.9	11.0	1.5	20.8	–	–
2006	37.5	29.6	29.6	12.5	23.7	17.8	10.9	1.3	20.7	–	–
2007	34.8	15.4	22.2	10.2	24.2	18.2	10.2	1.1	21.3	–	–
2008	33.3	31.0	19.0	14.5	24.5	18.3	10.8	1.2	21.5	–	–
2009	21.1	25.8	26.9	14.5	25.3	18.8	10.4	1.3	22.0	–	–
2010	33.3	21.4	30.3	17.2	25.5	19.5	10.9	1.1	22.6	50.8	52.5
2011	50.0	–	35.3	16.3	25.9	19.6	11.8	1.2	22.7	–	–
2012	–	–	30.8	9.0	26.2	19.9	11.3	0.9	22.9	–	–
2013	–	–	28.1	16.6	26.5	20.1	11.7	1.9	23.0	–	–
2014	–	–	25.7	14.7	26.7	20.2	11.5	2.8	23.0	–	–
2015	–	–	25.9	–	26.9	20.3	11.5	2.9	23.1	–	–
2016	–	–	21.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Coded columns: female share of classified criminal characters in episodes broadcast that year. NCVS: female-only offenders in serious violence incidents with known offender sex (including mixed groups); UCR: arrests; Census: population. Entries are percentages; – denotes no data.